

AG2500 Master's Thesis for IAGG

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1. Learning outcomes

After completing the course the student is expected to be able to:

A. Knowledge and understanding

- Understand and independently apply the requirements and standards of social science research in order to complete an original research project relevant to international administration and global governance;

B. Skills and abilities

- Independently plan, carry out, and present a medium-scale research project that meets academic standards of reliability, validity, originality, organization and effective communication;
- Creatively, critically and independently identify, formulate and delimit an original scientific question of relevance to international administration and global governance,
- Creatively and independently select an appropriate methodological approach to answer a specified research question;
- Systematically and critically gather, compile empirical data and/or identify and evaluate existing empirical data, and determine whether the data are sufficient and appropriate to answer a research question and with what level of confidence;
- Communicate the results, orally and in writing, to different audiences, both in academic and policy contexts;
- Independently produce text in accordance with good academic practice, including proper citation technique and use of references

C. Judgment and approach

- Critically evaluate the reliability of conclusions and findings of academic research and policy evaluations;
- Identify and critically assess ethical issues related to research on human behaviour.

2. Ethics and integrity

As in all academic writing, the thesis must be your own work entirely, and any direct quotes and content taken from other sources must be correctly referenced. For guides for reference lists see for example [OUP](#) or [GU's](#) list of reference styles. You may choose whichever reference style you prefer but use one system consistently.

The use of generative AI to create content is prohibited. AI tools may be used for editing and polishing to improve the language. Students who violate this rule will be reported to the Disciplinary Board for using “unauthorized aids” (see GU's rules for disciplinary matters).

3. Schedule

The course consists of an introductory lecture, final seminars to discuss the theses, and independent work with your supervisor. Please see the course's Canvas page for schedule details.

Marcia Grimes will have office hours every other week throughout the spring. The schedule and link are also on the course's Canvas page.

4. Thesis Course content

Each student will formulate a research question that addresses a gap in relevant academic research, and then plan and complete an independent research project. Writing the master's thesis will develop students' ability to plan and manage large projects, and collect and analyze social science data to answer an original research question of relevance to international administration and global governance. Each student will receive support and substantive guidance from a thesis advisor. Students will present and defend the thesis at a final seminar, as well as act as discussant on another student's thesis.

5. Supervisors

Supervisors can be from the Department of Political Science or the School of Global Studies. After submitting your topic proposal, you will be matched with a supervisor.

You will have regular meetings with your supervisor during the thesis writing process. To make the most of your supervision meetings, send a draft of all or portions of the thesis ahead of each meeting. It is also a very good idea at each meeting to decide a time for the next meeting and set goals for what work you will complete by that meeting. Please note that your supervisor needs to read and approve an almost final version of your thesis before you submit. If your supervisor deems that the thesis needs additional work, you will have to wait until the subsequent submission opportunity.

6. Evaluation of Theses

A. Grading procedure

The theses will be screened and then graded by two members of the faculty, a principal and a secondary examiner. Screening takes place the day of submission with the aim to ensure that it meets the minimum requirements of a Pass. If the examiners deem that more work is required before the thesis receives a passing grade, they will recommend that the student withdraw the thesis and submit at a later date. Please note however that the screening process is not the formal grading process. The final grade will be set after the more careful evaluation and discussion between examiners.

Each thesis will be discussed at a seminar in which a student, designated as discussant, as well as the principal examiner comment on the thesis (see below for more information about the seminar). Other students in attendance are also encouraged to participate actively. After the seminars, examiners meet to discuss each thesis and assign grades.

In addition to the notification of the grade, the principal grader will complete an evaluation form (see below). The evaluation form will reflect both the principal and secondary graders' evaluation of the thesis on each of the grading criteria. Students in the double degree program with Konstanz will also be evaluated by and receive comments from a third evaluator from KU.

Each student is also required to act as discussant for one other student's thesis, as well as attend a minimum of four additional thesis seminars. More on each of these below.

B. Evaluation criteria

A good thesis is clearly structured and internally cohesive. Examiners evaluate the theses on the following criteria:

Research aim and question

The research aim and questions should correspond to one another such that answers to the individual research questions will result in fulfilling the aim of the study. Also, are the aim and questions of the research project:

- sufficiently specific for a study of this scope?
- relevant to the field of international administration and global governance?
- situated in previous research such that the gap and contribution to academic and policy discussions is made clear?

Review of previous research

- Does the literature review thematically survey the literature and situate the study in relevant research? Does it use this review to specify the gap and explain the relevance of the research question as well as the contribution of the study?
- Does it identify, if relevant, alternative explanations to be taken into account in the empirical analysis?

Theory and operationalization

- Does the theory section lay the foundation for the empirical investigation to follow?
- Does it define relevant concepts and do these definitions correspond to the operationalization and measurement of these concepts? (Operationalization and measurement can be discussed either when presenting the analytical framework, or in the section on data and methods)
- Does the analytical framework or hypotheses operationalize the theory adequately? In other words, does it explain how the theoretical concepts are measured/captured/identified in the empirical analysis? Is the analytical framework sufficiently specific so as to allow you to determine whether, and to what extent, each phenomenon identified as relevant in the theory (i.e. each variable in the hypotheses) exist in the context(s) studied? In sum, the analytical framework/hypotheses clearly present which concepts or causal relations will be analyzed in the empirical analyses. The analytical framework thus summarizes theoretical concepts and expectations, should not introduce new concepts, and should structure the empirical analyses.

Methodological approach and design

Does the methods section:

- clearly describe the method and design of the study, including a description and critical evaluation of data, material, case selection, and sources?
- justify the choice of and discuss the validity, reliability and limitations of the data and the methodological approach?
- discuss the limitations of the study and possible implications of those limitations for the findings of the empirical investigation?
- discuss ethical considerations of the study?

Analysis and results

Are the empirical analyses and discussion and interpretation of results:

- presented clearly and effectively?
- theoretically informed, i.e. does the analytical framework carry over into the empirical analyses in a clear and systematic way?
- reasonable?
- reflect an awareness of the validity and reliability of results?
- carried out in accordance with standards specified by the methodological approach employed? And
- is the data sufficient to answer the research question?

Conclusion, discussion of results

Does the concluding discussion:

- clearly restate the main results of the empirical analyses
- relate the findings of the study to the theory and larger research field?
- consider the policy implications of the study?

Overall quality

Does the thesis:

- demonstrate an ability to think critically and analytically, and to engage independently both with empirical material and in research debates?
- communicate effectively and in language appropriate for an academic audience?
- cite sources correctly?

The table on the next page summarizes these criteria.

C. Grades and Grading

A thesis may receive the grades Pass with distinction, Pass, Pass with minor changes, and Fail. A student must also receive the grade Pass for the seminar.

The grading of theses is not an exercise in ticking boxes. The thesis grade will reflect an assessment of all of the points above. Strengths in one area can to some extent compensate for shortcomings in others. In the cases in which the grade for the thesis is on the borderline between two grades, a student's responses at the seminar may help to clarify minor points, which can influence the thesis grade. This is the exception rather than the rule, however, and the written text must speak for itself.

To Pass the seminar, students need to be able to clarify choices made in all portions of the thesis. Examiners may for example ask for clarifications regarding key academic studies the thesis builds, theoretical model or operationalization of concepts, choices of data, methodological approach, and relevance of the findings for our more general understanding of the issues studied.

If a student is unable to answer the questions of the examiner, they will receive an additional opportunity to meet with the examiner to address the questions. If responses still do not adequately clarify the examiners' question, examiners may require the student to revise the thesis by assigning the thesis a grade 'Pass with minor changes' or 'Fail'.

The section below provides further information on the difference between 'Pass with minor changes' and 'Fail'.

D. Pass with minor changes versus Fail

Unlike most other graded assignments in the IAGG program, students whose master's theses do not receive a passing grade only receive one chance to revise their work and raise it to the standard of a passing grade. If minor revisions are needed, the principal grader will provide the student clear and concise instructions about required revisions for it to receive a passing grade. A thesis revised cannot receive the grade Pass with distinction. The required changes should be of a scope and scale that they can be addressed and remedied in approximately two week's time. If the thesis requires work that is greater than what can be accomplished in two weeks, the thesis will receive the grade Fail. A failing grade means the student must submit a reworked version of the thesis in the next submission round and once again present the thesis at a seminar as well as act as discussant on another student's thesis. The screening process is intended to avoid this outcome, but as stated above, is not a guarantee of the final grade.

E. Summary of evaluation criteria

	Pass with Distinction	Pass	Fail
Research aim	Original question, relevant to policy and social science debates, the gap clearly explained.	Original and relevant to policy and social science debates, gap identified	Research aim not clearly presented or not linked to rest of the thesis.
Theoretical discussion and review of existing research	Thorough and clear summary and analysis of relevant previous research, presented thematically. Clear and appropriate definitions of key concepts and/or causal relations, operationalized as hypotheses or analytical framework.	Clear presentation of relevant previous research, presented thematically. Clear and appropriate definitions of key concepts, which inform the hypotheses or analytical framework.	Discussion of previous research thin or presented author by author. Theories and concepts not well captured in analytical framework.
Research questions	Clear, justified and explained in terms of existing research and the research aim. Answers to the RQs	Clearly formulated and linked to existing research and the aim of the thesis.	Unclear or not set in relation to existing research.

	should add up to addressing the overarching aim.		
Methodological approach and design	Appropriate for answering the research questions, clearly explained, alternative approaches and choices discussed. The choice of empirical cases is clearly and reasonably justified in theoretical terms.	Sound and suitable for answering the research questions. The empirical cases justified in empirical terms ('no previous studies focus on this issue in this setting?').	Research methods insufficiently discussed or not suitable for answering the research questions. Case selection not sufficiently discussed.
Data and material	Clearly presented and relevance to theory explained. Insightful discussion of reliability, validity as well as and limitations of the data. Enough data to answer the RQ adequately.	Presented and relevance to theory explained. Discussion of strengths and weaknesses of the data. Enough data to answer the RQ adequately.	Selection and evaluation of data and material falls short of scientific standards or not discussed at all. Insufficient data to answer the research question.
Analysis and Results	Research method correctly applied in a way that indicates ability to think independently and analytically. Thorough and in-depth exploration of and clear answers to the research questions..	Research method correctly applied. Thorough and in-depth exploration of the research questions.	Analyses not clearly structured by theory. Answers to research questions not well substantiated by empirical analysis, or research method not applied correctly. Research questions not answered systematically.
Conclusion and discussion of results	Clearly present the answers to the research questions, generality of the findings discussed, policy and theoretical implications of the study explained.	Clearly present the answers to the research questions. Results set in relation to previous research.	Unclear discussion of the findings of the study in relation to research questions and previous research.
Overall quality	Well structured and written in accordance with all standards of academic writing.	Good or acceptable readability. Correct referencing used.	Unclear or difficult to understand. Errors in referencing sources.

F. Seminars and the role of the discussant

The primary function of the seminars is to discuss and respond to questions from the discussant and from the two examiners. The seminars are 1 hour and 15 minutes long.

The first part of the seminar will consist of questions from the discussant.

Discussants should read the theses very carefully and consider the choices the author made along the way. Could they have made other choices? How might it have affected the findings and conclusions? Think about the points highlighted in the criteria above. The discussant should prepare 7-10 questions to discuss with the author. This part of the seminar should take around 40 minutes.

Please note that the primary examiner may ask the discussant to clarify or explain the reasoning behind the questions.

Focus on what you think needs clarification, could have been done better, or other issues related to the study that you feel perhaps should have been discussed in the thesis. Make sure to end each comment with a question rather than simply stating what you think could have been done better. This opens up for discussion that can yield new insights.

The key to being a good discussant is to be as clear and constructive as possible. If you find it uncomfortable to offer and receive criticism on your work, it may help to remind yourself that you are not criticizing or calling into question the person per se, but rather offering rigorous and well thought out feedback on a text they have written.

You will be graded on how well you carry out the role of discussant, though you can only receive the grades Pass or Fail. A failing grade means you will have to submit comments on a different thesis in writing within a week after the seminar.

G. Seminar attendance

You are expected to attend all of the thesis seminars. However, if you for some reason unable to attend all the seminars, there is a minimum requirement, which is 6 seminars including the seminar at which your own thesis is discussed and the one at which you act as discussant. Make sure that you sign the attendance sheet at each seminar that you attend. If you submit in September or February, there may be fewer than 6 seminars, so it is a good idea to attend seminars in May to ensure that you complete this course requirement.

7. Formatting and formal requirements

A. Length

The thesis should be between 6000 and 20,000 words, including all footnotes and references in the text, the abstract, and reference list. Appendices are not included in the word count. These limits are strict and **a thesis will not be accepted if it exceeds the upper limit**. Indicate on the title page the exact number of words in the thesis. If you find yourself over the word limit, there is only one solution: edit, edit, edit.

B. Abstract

A 250 word abstract should accompany the thesis. The abstract should very briefly present the research aim, the design and methods used, and the results of the analysis.

C. Title Page

Please use the template provided on Canvas.

D. Submission guidelines

The deadline for confirming that you will submit your thesis is around three weeks before the deadline for uploading it on Canvas. There is a tool on Canvas (i.e. a “project group” you can join) in order to register your name and preliminary title of your thesis.

The deadline for submissions is one week before the seminars. The thesis must be uploaded to Canvas as a .pdf document (see Canvas for details). We also ask you to complete the form granting the department permission to publish your thesis electronically. Turn the form in to Wilma Holmestrand. This is, however, voluntary.

All of the theses turned in by the deadline will be available for everyone to download on the next day, along with a schedule of seminars, which also indicates who will be discussant on which thesis.

E. What happens if I miss the deadline?

If you are unable to submit the thesis by the deadline, you will have to wait until the next round of seminars to submit the thesis. Unless otherwise indicated, there will be one or two opportunities per semester to submit your thesis. You must be present in Sweden to defend your thesis at the final seminar and submitting later than your intended date of graduation may result in visa complications or additional costs if you have to return to Sweden at a later point in time to attend the seminar.

F. Referencing and academic integrity

The thesis must comply with all the formal requirements of academic writing. All theses will be scanned digitally for signs of plagiarism. If plagiarism is detected, the thesis will receive a failing grade, the case will be referred to the University's Disciplinary Committee, and the student *will be required to write a new thesis on a different topic*.

The thesis should in its entirety be your own original writing, and not written by someone else or generative AI. Please see the full IAGG Policy on Plagiarism attached.

G. Additional Information

If you plan on handing in your thesis in September, be aware that you may not be able to receive feedback from your supervisor during the summer.

The version of the thesis you hand in is the final version. If you find typos or other errors, you cannot change this and upload a new version after the deadline.

If you are given the grade 'Pass with minor changes' after handing in May/June, your revision will not be evaluated until after the summer break. This means that you will not receive a grade until late August, which can mean delays in receiving your diploma.

IAGG Policy on Plagiarism

Attempts to deceive during examinations

An attempt to deceive during examinations means that a student has attempted to give an impression of their performance in a written exam or some of form of assessment that is not true. That is what is commonly referred to as cheating, or attempting to cheat. There are different kinds of attempts to deceive, such as plagiarism, prohibited aids and prohibited collaboration. Deception can also take other forms.

- **Plagiarism** means that a student has presented someone else's text or other material as if it were their own text or material.
- **Prohibited aid** means that a student has used aids, including AI, that were not permitted according to the instructions.
- **Prohibited collaboration** means that students have collaborated with each other in breach of the instructions.

Plagiarism: Copying material from the Internet, from books, journals, reports, or from a fellow student and then presenting it as one's own is strictly forbidden! Plagiarism is theft of someone else's work and will result in immediate fail of the assignment. Please note that the inclusion of a source in a bibliography list is not in itself sufficient attribution of another's work. In addition, unless it is a proper citation, including the use of quotation marks ("xxx") and with a reference, any direct copying of text is forbidden. All submitted student work is screened with a program called *Ouriginal*, which compares a student's written work with published materials (including everything published on the internet) and all the work from prior students, to detect plagiarism. The material you have read and based your arguments and factual statements on should always be referenced using proper referencing technique. More information on references and how to avoid plagiarism can be found here: <https://studentportal.gu.se/english/help-and-guidance/search-read-write/reference-management-and-plagiarism>

Prohibited aid: All your submitted texts should be your own original writing, and not written by someone else or generated by AI. Unless there are specific instructions for the use of AI for an assignment, it should not be used and presented as your own text. The use of any tools to cheat during on campus exams (e.g. DISA) is also strictly forbidden.

Prohibited collaboration: students can discuss their work, but individual submissions must be your own original writing, and hence not too similar the work of others. Be extra careful to avoid using common notes from such collaborations.

Any kind of cheating on examinations is considered a serious offence. Proved or suspected cheating will be reported to the Disciplinary Committee of the University of Gothenburg, in accordance with the procedure of disciplinary matters at the department of political science.

The consequences may be severe for a student if found guilty. A student may be suspended from classes and campus for a determined time-period (from 3 weeks to half a year), which will result in a temporary suspension of all financial aid (including CSN) and may jeopardize a student's residence permit status. More information on disciplinary matters, including plagiarism and its consequences, can be found here: <https://studentportal.gu.se/english/study-environment-and-rules/disciplinary-matters/>

